

Early African civilizations

Africa was home to some of the wealthiest civilizations of the ancient world. The earliest rose around 5,000 years ago in northeast Africa where the people of ancient Egypt (see pp.20–23) and the Nubia region established civilizations that thrived for several thousand years. Later, advanced cultures emerged in West Africa and in the east, where the Kingdom of Aksum developed into a major world power.

ANCIENT KINGDOMS OF AFRICA

c. 1070 BCE–350 CE

The Kingdom of Kush, in modern-day Sudan, is the most powerful of a series of civilizations that rules in ancient Nubia, south of Egypt along the Nile valley. It is known as the “Land of the Bow,” owing to its skilled archers, and grows rich on trading resources and goods such as gold, ivory, and animal pelts.



NOK TERRA-COTTA FIGURE

500 BCE–200 CE

The Nok culture flourishes in modern-day Nigeria. Nok people create impressive terra-cotta artifacts and are also skilled metalworkers, using sophisticated technology to make iron tools and weapons.

202–46 BCE

The Kingdom of Numidia rules a large part of northwest Africa. The Numidian cavalry is famous for its military tactics, which it uses to fight against the Carthaginians in 151–150 BCE.

80 BCE–825 CE

In eastern Africa, the Kingdom of Aksum rises to become a powerful trading empire. It develops a writing system that is still used by modern-day Ethiopian and Eritrean languages. Around 328 CE, the kingdom converts to Christianity.

KUSHITE ART ►

Like the ancient Egyptians, the people of Kush built many large pyramids over the burial chambers of their kings and queens. These were decorated with detailed paintings and carvings. This carving, on a stone slab found in the royal capital of Meroë, shows a Kushite prince slaying his enemy.

